



AS I WRITE this piece, I can't help but think of the ubiquitous 'sliced bread,' which has been around for over nine decades and continues to be a part of our daily lives. It leads me to believe that when independent India marks its centennial in 25 years, there will most likely be a few technological breakthroughs that qualify as the "best thing since sliced bread".

When pioneering technologies from a previous era become old or obsolete, they do not simply disappear. They linger in our minds for a long time and become signposts in our lives. People of my generation will remember how much of a difference Walkman players made to our lives in the 1980s when we could take our music with us wherever we went. Whenever I think of that device, I am reminded of my growing up years in Mumbai.

Technology, in my opinion, improves the lives of people and strengthens communities. As the helmsman of a large purpose-led business organisation, I believe scientific progress will catalyse our efforts to rise for a more equal world. The advances made by our country give me hope for a bright future for our people. Aside from that, it is encouraging to observe how easily Indians have adapted to emerging technologies.

Some researchers say India is the second-largest smartphone

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India's big bet on technology and tech-enabled businesses will ensure the country's rise in the coming decades



BY ANISH SHAH

market in the world with nearly 800 million users. In terms of internet penetration, nearly 50 per cent of our population—about 660 million people—have already logged in. There are various studies that state that roughly 96 per cent of our population could be hooked to the internet by 2040. These data points lead me to believe that the internet and smartphones will be the primary 'carriers' or 'distributors' of new technologies in our country. Non-web-based fields, such as healthcare, manufacturing, agriculture, power, etc., will also adopt newer ways of doing things. However, new technologies would only gain traction if they solve the big problems of our times.

Among all the issues confronting us today, social and economic inequality is the most crippling. While social equity may take time and higher thinking to achieve, a semblance of economic equity is a more attainable goal. Financial inclusion, easy access to credit and low-cost savings products are important pathways to haul our many millions out of poverty. The banking and financial services sector has already started using the